

MINUTES OF MEETING HELD August 18th 2025 OF GRADUATE AND PROFESSIONAL STUDENT COUNCIL, GENERAL COUNCIL

A meeting of the Graduate and Professional Student Council (GPSC), General Council (GC) was convened on Monday, August 18th at 6:00 PM held on SouthRec North Conference room and Zoom.

1. Call to Order

Present at the meeting were the following members of the:

- **(6) GPSC Executive Board (EB):** Mourad Abdennebi (President), Naama Levy, (Administrative Vice President), Travis Dean (Executive Vice President), Mehrdad Aghayari (Assembly Chair), Milad Hasankhani (Treasurer), Rishabh Bhattad (Secretary)
- **(20) GPSC General Council (GC):** Anna Roche, Harriet Olulo, Anam Rani Khaldi, Max Thomas, Kinsey Cline, Sarah Low, Joanna Joseph, Mohamadreza Ramenazi, Breanne Harvey, John Conley, Xuelun Tian, J Bryce Palmer, Matt Sandoval, Nicole Perry, Esha Rajadhyaksha, Amanda Chriswell, Precious Innocent Mastala, Holly Thomas, Lucia Luna Aurelia, Hannah Szoke.
- **(4) Advisors and Staff:** Solange Quintana , Elham Chelabi, Roselyn Amamoo, David Bradshaw

Quorum met: 26 Officers present

2. Call to Audience

The EB may not discuss items that are not on the agenda. Therefore, action taken as a result of public comment will be limited to directing staff to study the matter or scheduling the matter for consideration at a later date.

3. Review and Approve Meeting Minutes

The minutes from the previous meeting (July 9, 2025) were reviewed and approved.

4. Officer Reports

- President:

- Has been in numerous meetings with university leadership (Provost, Deans, CFO, ISS, CAPS) to discuss GPSC priorities.
- Progress has been made on a potential 5% stipend increase for the next fiscal year, with the Provost and Dean on board.
- Proposals are being drafted for a pop-up pantry, an international student emergency fund, and campus safety protocols.

- Vice President:

- Working on surveys to gather data on GA funding inequities and student satisfaction with advisors/supervisors.
- Emphasized the shared, non-hierarchical leadership model of GPSC and encouraged all representatives to take agency.

- Executive Vice President:

- Renewed the Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) with the Student Union and is in process of updating MOUs with CAPS, the Bookstore, and Campus Rec.
- Urged all representatives to sign up for one internal and one external committee via the provided Google Sheet.
- The upcoming representative retreat will include sessions for committees to define their purpose and goals for the year.

- Treasurer:

- Representatives will receive their first stipend payment by the end of August through their bursar account.
- A link was sent out to collect student ID information for payment processing; representatives who have not completed it should do so.

- Assembly Chair:

- Meeting's agenda and videos will be uploaded in box.

- Secretary:

- Representatives must sign attendance sheet. Attendance is mandatory to receive stipends; representatives cannot miss more than two meetings per semester without a proxy.

- Secretary:

- Microsoft Teams channels are being set up for general announcements and for each individual committee.
- A welcome letter will be sent to all graduate students on August 25th.
- New LinkedIn and TikTok accounts will be created to increase student engagement. The website will be updated with new photos and bios.

5. New Business & Action Items

- International Student Hardship Fund:

- The existing university hardship fund, previously only for domestic students, is being amended to include international students.
- The current budget is \$50,000. The council discussed whether to keep the award amount high (e.g., \$2,500 for ~20 students) or lower it to serve more students.
- The consensus was to set a cap (e.g., \$1,500) and award funds on a case-by-case, sliding scale basis.

- Student Showcase:

- The Provost and Graduate College Dean are supportive of bringing back the Student Showcase event.
- A committee is being formed to create a proposal and secure funding. Representatives interested in joining should contact Mourad or Mehrdad.

- Welcome Event:

- The Director of Communications presented several ideas, including icebreaker name tags, a "Future Me" letter-writing station, and a free professional headshot hub.
- Potential venues include MSA Annex and Cork & Craft. The event will likely be held on a Friday in September.

- Campus Pantry Access:

- A proposal to expand access hours for the Campus Pantry was declined by the center due to staffing and budget issues.
- The council will continue to advocate for solutions, including potentially organizing GPSC volunteers to help staff the pantry during extended hours.

- Writing Skills Improvement Program (WSIP):

- It was reported that the WSIP is being discontinued due to budget cuts, which is a major concern for students who rely on it.
- Action: The President will follow up with the College of Humanities to gather data on the program's usage and explore alternatives.
- Resource: David Bradshaw (GPSC Advisor) noted that the Graduate Writing Lab at the Graduate Center remains a valuable resource for writing support.

- International Student Grant:

- A proposal is being developed for a new grant specifically for international students to address their unique financial circumstances.
- ISS and the Provost are supportive of the idea. The council will work on a formal proposal this semester to be implemented next year.

6. Constituency Concerns & Meeting Modality

- Constituency Meetings:

- Representatives were encouraged to hold constituency meetings and utilize a potential centralized survey to gather feedback.

- GC Meetings:

- A discussion was held regarding in-person vs. online meetings. It was clarified that while in-person attendance is strongly encouraged to foster community, a Zoom option will always be available for accessibility and for those who cannot attend in person. Meetings will continue to be public and recorded.

7. Motion to Adjourn

- Motion to adjourn the meeting by Assembly Chair:

- The meeting was adjourned at 7:36 pm.

Dated this 18th day of August 2025

Graduate and Professional Student Council Executive Board

Rishabh Bhattad, Secretary